

GCE O LEVEL ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Syllabus 1184 — Paper 3

LISTENING COMPREHENSION

Complete Revision & Strategy Guide

Most students who underperform in Listening Comprehension do not fail because they cannot understand English — they fail because they apply the wrong strategy to the wrong question.

This guide will show you that Paper 3 contains four distinct question types, each demanding a fundamentally different approach. You will learn exactly what to do before the recording plays, during each playback, and in the moments after — so that on examination day, every mark is claimed with method, not chance.

PAPER AT A GLANCE

Total marks	30 marks — 10% of overall O Level English grade
Duration	Approximately 45 minutes
Section A	22 marks — Parts 1, 2 & 3 — audio played TWICE
Section B	8 marks — Part 4 — audio played ONCE only
Question types	4 — MCQ · Multiple Matching · Note-Completion · Note-Taking
Syllabus	SEAB Syllabus 1184

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Question Types at a Glance — Consolidated Comparison

Use this page as your master reference. Each column is one question type. The **Listening Mode** row is the single most important row in this document — it defines which mental gear to use for each part.

	PART 1 MCQ	PART 2 Multiple Matching	PART 3 Note-Completion	PART 4 Note-Taking
Questions / Marks	Q1–6 6 marks	Q7–12 6 marks	Q13–22 10 marks	Q23 (i)–(viii) 8 marks
Playbacks	TWICE	TWICE	TWICE	ONCE ONLY
Answer format	Circle A/B/C/D	Write one letter A–G per speaker	1–2 words or short phrase per gap	Brief notes (no full sentences needed)
LISTENING MODE	INTERPRETATION What does the speaker mean or imply?	INTERPRETATION What does the speaker feel or think?	TRANSCRIPTION What exact word did the speaker use?	TRANSCRIPTION What exact information did the speaker give?
Key pre-listen action	Underline question stem focus word. Do not over-read the options.	Read ALL 7 A–G options. Write a 2-word paraphrase clue beside each.	Read the ENTIRE organiser including side columns. Mark word class per gap.	Scan ALL (i)–(viii) headings in one sweep. Prepare abbreviations now.
Core technique	Correct answer = paraphrase of audio. Exact echo of audio = likely trap. Answer follows contrast marker.	Track WHOSE view it is. Speaker's OWN feeling comes AFTER reporting others' views. No letter used twice.	Write the HEARD word — not a synonym. Grammar must fit the gap. Both words needed in double-blank gaps.	Write while listening — never stop. Listen for topic pivots, not exact heading words. Never leave blank.
Biggest trap	Choosing the option that echoes a word from the audio verbatim — placed out of context.	Matching the FIRST sentiment heard, which is often another person's view, not the speaker's own.	Writing a synonym instead of the exact heard word — even a correct synonym may be marked wrong.	Leaving a blank because an answer was missed. A best guess scores higher than zero.

KEY INSIGHT **Parts 1 & 2 — INTERPRETATION:** The answer is rarely the speaker's exact words. Listen for meaning and emotion. **Parts 3 & 4 — TRANSCRIPTION:** Write what the speaker actually said. Never substitute a synonym. Applying the wrong mode to any part costs marks that technique — not language ability — should have secured.



Section A — Pre-Listening Strategy: What to Do Before the Audio Plays

The most valuable time in a listening examination is the silence before the audio starts. Every part has a scripted introduction — use that time and every music interlude between parts to prepare. Students who sit passively during introductions consistently lose avoidable marks.

Part	What to do during reading / introduction time	Why it matters
Part 1 MCQ	1. Read each question stem and underline the key focus word. 2. Skim options A–D but do not over-study them — they will be paraphrased in the audio. 3. Focus on the QUESTION. It tells you exactly what detail to listen for.	Prevents being caught off guard. Stops you listening for the wrong detail entirely.
Part 2 Matching	1. Read ALL seven A–G statements before the audio starts. 2. Write a 2-word paraphrase beside each (e.g. ‘G: annoyed by others’). 3. One letter is unused — do not try to force it onto a speaker.	Builds a mental map of all possible feelings so you can match faster once each speaker begins.
Part 3 Note-Completion	1. Read the ENTIRE graphic organiser — all boxes, including side columns. 2. For each blank, mark the expected word class: (n) noun, (v) verb, (num) number, (pl) place. 3. Predict a rough answer for 2–3 gaps to prime your listening.	The organiser is non-linear. Pre-reading prevents losing your place when the audio moves between boxes.
Part 4 Note-Taking	1. Scan ALL (i)–(viii) headings in a single sweep before audio begins. 2. Prepare abbreviations: gov, pop, env, adv, disadv, approx. 3. CRITICAL: There is only ONE playback. This scan is your only safety net.	Single playback means preparation is everything. Knowing the structure lets you write without hesitation.



Section B — Part 1: Multiple-Choice Questions (MCQ)

Overview: Questions 1–6 | 6 marks (1 each) | 3 short recordings | 2 MCQ items per recording | 4 options (A–D). Skills tested: Gist · Attitude · Opinion · Agreement between two speakers · Inference.

Question Type 1: Attitude / Feeling Questions

Technique: Listen for the speaker's tone, modal verbs (*would, might, seem*), and emotional vocabulary. A speaker's hesitation or hedging language (*I suppose, not exactly*) often reveals their true attitude more clearly than their direct statements.

- Step 1. Pre-read:** Underline the focus word in the question stem (e.g. *'how she felt at the start of...'*). Do not over-read the options.
- Step 2. First listen:** Identify the speaker's overall mood. Note a rough answer in the margin. Do not circle yet.
- Step 3. Eliminate:** Cross out two options you are confident are wrong.
- Step 4. Second listen:** Confirm. Listen especially for contrast markers (*but, however, actually*) — the true answer comes **after** them.
- Step 5. Circle clearly:** One letter only. Cross out any previous mark if you change your mind.

Recording 1 — Interview with a top gymnast.

Q1: How did she feel at the start of her first major championships?

A Nervous B Excited C Disappointed D Confident

The

gymnast says: *"I mean, I tried to stay calm, but honestly, my hands were shaking... I kept telling myself it would be fine, but I wasn't really convinced."*

Analysis: She explicitly mentions shaking hands and a lack of self-conviction. The contrast between her words (*'stay calm'*) and her actual state (*'hands were shaking', 'wasn't convinced'*) reveals anxiety.

Answer: A — Nervous.

Note: Option B is a distractor — the word *'excited'* may appear elsewhere in the interview but does not describe her feeling *at the start*.



Question Type 2: Agreement Between Two Speakers

Technique: Wait for **both** speakers to comment on the topic before choosing an answer. A negative agreement counts as agreement — if both speakers independently express the same reservation, that is agreement. Do not select an answer based on only one speaker's view.

Step 1. Pre-read: Identify this as an agreement question. Prepare to track two speakers separately.

Step 2. First listen: Note each speaker's view with a brief phrase (e.g. 'Sp1: unimpressed with taste; Sp2: agrees').

Step 3. Eliminate: Remove options that only one speaker supports.

Step 4. Second listen: Verify the agreed point is expressed by both, not merely tolerated by one.

Step 5. Circle clearly: One letter only.

Recording 2 — Two friends discussing a vegan restaurant.

Q3: The two friends agree that the food there...

A was reasonably priced B was not very flavourful

C looked unappealing D had interesting variety

1: *"It was fine, I suppose, but I didn't really taste much."*

Speaker 2: *"Yeah, I wouldn't say it was particularly strong in flavour either."*

Analysis: Both speakers independently comment on a lack of strong flavour. Neither mentions price, appearance, or variety in a shared way.

Answer: B — was not very flavourful.

Note: Both speakers' agreement is expressed through understatement (*'didn't really taste much'*, *'not particularly strong'*) — a classic listening trap for students who expect more direct agreement.



Question Type 3: Qualified / Inference Questions

Technique: Qualified statements test whether you can identify a condition or limitation on what the speaker says. Key words: *only, mainly, unlikely, except, unless, at first, eventually*. Missing one of these qualifiers produces an answer that is almost — but not quite — correct.

- Step 1. Pre-read:** Look for modal verbs and qualifying language in the question (e.g. *‘unlikely to’, ‘mainly uses’*).
- Step 2. First listen:** Note the exact degree of the speaker’s claim — not the general direction of it.
- Step 3. Eliminate:** Remove options that overstate or understate the speaker’s actual position.
- Step 4. Second listen:** Confirm the qualifier matches the option you have selected.
- Step 5. Circle clearly:** One letter only.

Recording 2 — Two friends discussing a vegan restaurant.

Q4: He thinks he is _____ to adopt a vegan diet.

A definitely going B unlikely C already considering D required

Speaker:

“I enjoyed the food well enough, but I can’t see myself giving up meat entirely. It’s just not really for me at this point.”

Analysis: The speaker expresses no positive intention to adopt veganism. His hedged language (*‘can’t see myself’, ‘not really for me’*) indicates it is improbable, not impossible.

Answer: B — unlikely.

Note: Option A would require a direct statement of intention. Option C requires evidence of active consideration. The speaker does neither.



Read each question and select the best answer A, B, C or D. Apply the appropriate technique for each question type.

1. A speaker says: *"It was daunting, to say the least — I kept second-guessing everything."* How does the speaker feel? A Angry B Confident C Apprehensive D Indifferent
2. Two speakers discuss a film. Speaker 1: *"The pacing felt slow."* Speaker 2: *"Yeah, it dragged a bit for me too."* They agree the film... A had poor acting B was too long C moved too slowly D lacked action
3. A reviewer says: *"I wouldn't call it a masterpiece, but it's certainly worth reading."* The reviewer thinks the book is... A outstanding B worthwhile C disappointing D mediocre
4. A speaker mentions: *"I mainly focused on the first chapter."* This means they... A only read one chapter B spent most time on chapter one C disliked the other chapters D skipped the rest
5. A gymnast says: *"By the final round, I actually felt more at ease."* This tells us she felt nervous... A throughout B at the end C at the start D only during training
6. A speaker says: *"I wouldn't say I'm against the idea — I just haven't decided yet."* She is... A opposed B in favour C undecided D enthusiastic
7. Two speakers discuss a restaurant. Speaker 1: *"The service was excellent."* Speaker 2: *"I agree — the staff were very attentive."* They agree about the... A food quality B prices C atmosphere D service
8. A reviewer says: *"The title is a little misleading, if I'm honest."* What does the reviewer suggest about the title? A It is accurate. B It is clever. C It does not reflect the content. D It is too simple.
9. A speaker describes a project: *"It's not what I expected, but I've come around to it."* She now feels... A disappointed B accepting C enthusiastic D confused
10. A speaker says: *"I'd go again, but only if the prices came down."* This means he is... A unlikely to return B willing to return under a condition C very eager to return D opposed to returning



Section C — Part 2: Multiple Matching

Overview: Questions 7–12 | 6 marks (1 each) | 6 speakers | 7 A–G statements | ONE extra option unused
| **NO letter may be used more than once.**

The A–G options are always **opinion or feeling labels**, not factual statements. Your task is to identify each speaker's own dominant feeling about a shared topic. A typical set of A–G options might be:

- A determined to make the most of it
- B unsure what the purpose of it is
- C pleased to have been chosen for a particular role
- D impressed by the planning that has gone into it
- E worried about how demanding it will be
- F excited about an opportunity it will bring
- G disappointed by the attitude of certain people towards it

Question Type 1: Identifying a Speaker's Own Feeling

Technique: Track **whose** view is being expressed at every moment. Speakers frequently describe what others think before stating their own opinion. The speaker's own feeling is almost always expressed *after* a contrast or pivot (*'but I feel'*, *'for me personally'*, *'what I really think is'*).

- Step 1. Pre-read:** Read ALL seven A–G options before the audio starts. Write a 2-word paraphrase beside each (e.g. G: 'annoyed by others').
- Step 2. First listen:** For each speaker, jot a 2–3 word description of their feeling in pencil (e.g. 'Sp3: upset about teammates'). Do not commit to a letter yet.
- Step 3. Map to A–G:** After each speaker, lightly pencil the best-matching letter. If two options seem equally likely, note both for the second listen.
- Step 4. Second listen:** Focus on uncertain speakers. Confirm the feeling is the speaker's **OWN** and not a reported view.
- Step 5. Final answers:** Write one capital letter per speaker. Verify no letter appears twice.

Speaker 1 talks about a school science project.

"I honestly couldn't believe they picked us — I'm still a bit shocked, but really pleased about it."

Analysis:

The speaker mentions shock first, but the pivot word *'but'* signals the true feeling follows: she is *'really pleased'* about being selected for a particular role.

Answer: C — pleased to have been chosen for a particular role.

Note: Do not select the shock/disbelief as the answer — it is mentioned only to contextualise the main feeling, which is pleasure at selection.



Speaker 4 talks about the same science project.

“The others on my team aren’t really taking it seriously. I keep trying to tell them how important it is, but they just don’t seem to care. It’s really frustrating.”

Analysis:

The speaker describes others’ attitudes (‘not taking it seriously’, ‘don’t seem to care’) before expressing their own reaction: ‘really frustrating’ about others’ lack of commitment.

Answer: G — disappointed by the attitude of certain people towards it.

Note: The feeling is directed at *others’ behaviour*, not at the project itself. G requires ‘certain people’s attitude’ to be the source of the negative feeling — which matches precisely.

Speaker 6 talks about the same science project.

“I’m not sure I fully understand why we’re doing all this. My teacher says it’ll be useful for our portfolio, but I’m still not really getting the bigger picture.”

Analysis:

The speaker reports the teacher’s reasoning (‘useful for portfolio’) but their own view is that they do not understand the point: ‘not sure... why’, ‘not getting the bigger picture’.

Answer: B — unsure what the purpose of it is.

Note: This is a classic format — speaker reports someone else’s explanation, then reveals that they personally remain unconvinced. The answer is the speaker’s own unresolved uncertainty.



Read each speaker extract. Match to the correct A–G option. One option is not used. No option may be used more than once.

Options: A: relieved it is over B: proud of the result C: anxious about the workload D: grateful for support received E: critical of how it was organised F: surprised by how much was learned G: determined to improve next time

1. *"I didn't expect to come out of it knowing so much more. It was quite eye-opening, actually."*

2. *"Honestly, I'm just glad it's finished. I was really stressed throughout."* _____
3. *"I think the scheduling was really poorly managed. We never knew when things were due."*

4. *"I didn't do as well as I'd hoped, but I know exactly what I need to work on next time."*

5. *"I was really worried I wouldn't be able to keep up with everything, especially with exams coming up."* _____
6. *"I couldn't have done it without my teammates — they really helped me when I struggled."*

Questions 7–10: For each of the following, identify what the speaker's own feeling is after they describe others' views.

7. *"My parents thought it was a waste of time. I didn't agree — I thought it was really worthwhile."*
Speaker's own feeling: _____
8. *"My teacher said I did well, which was nice to hear, but honestly I know I could have done better."*
Speaker's own feeling: _____
9. *"Everyone else seemed calm, but I was quietly panicking the whole time."* Speaker's own feeling: _____
10. A speaker begins by describing a difficult group project. She mentions two teammates who were unhelpful, then says: *"But I wasn't going to let that stop me."* What does this reveal about the speaker? _____



Section D — Part 3: Note-Completion (Graphic Organiser)

Overview: Questions 13–22 | 10 marks (1 each) | Multi-box graphic organiser | 1–2 words or short phrase per gap. Skills tested: Accurate recall of the speaker’s exact words; ability to follow a non-linear structured layout.

Double-blank gaps: Some gaps require TWO answers (e.g. ‘*using software to _____ and _____*’). **Both must be correct for the single mark.**

Example of a printed answer in the graphic organiser:

Before films, mainly composed music for _____ **Answer: advertisements**

Question Type 1: Single-Word Gap

Technique: Identify the word class of the gap before the audio plays. If the gap follows ‘a’, your answer must be a singular noun beginning with a consonant. Write the exact word the speaker uses — do not substitute a synonym. Grammar and meaning must both fit the surrounding printed text.

Step 1. Pre-read: Read the entire graphic organiser, including side columns. Mark word class for each gap: (n), (v), (adj), (num), or (pl).

Step 2. First listen: Fill in confident gaps. For uncertain gaps, write a rough note or a question mark.

Step 3. Second listen: Fill remaining gaps. Write the EXACT heard word — not a paraphrase.

Step 4. Check: Read each gap back in context. Grammar fit? Spelling clear? Meaning preserved?

Graphic organiser gap: Speaker’s background: trained as a _____ composer.

Speaker says: “*Before I moved into film music, I worked primarily as a classical composer.*”

Word

class prediction: Adjective or noun modifier, following ‘a’.

Analysis: The speaker’s exact word is ‘*classical*’. The surrounding text ‘trained as a _____ composer’ confirms an adjective is needed.

Answer: classical

Note: Writing ‘*traditional*’ or ‘*formal*’ would be wrong — even if they seem related. The mark is awarded for the exact heard word.

Question Type 2: Double-Blank Gap

Technique: When a gap contains two blanks separated by ‘and’, both answers must come from the recording and both must be correct for the mark. Listen carefully for the pair — the speaker usually presents both items in the same breath. Do not leave either blank empty.

Step 1. Pre-read: Identify double-blank gaps during preparation time. Mark them as ‘(2)’ in pencil.

Step 2. First listen: Capture both words of the pair if possible. If only one is heard, write it and leave a space for the second.

Step 3. Second listen: Fill any missing half of the pair. Verify both words are from the recording.

Step 4. Check: Both blanks filled? Grammar fits both positions?



Graphic organiser gap: The composer uses software to _____ and _____ compositions.

Speaker says: *“These days I use software primarily to layer and edit my compositions.”*

Analysis:

Two verbs are needed. The speaker provides them consecutively: ‘layer’ and ‘edit’.

Answer: layer / edit

Note: The order matters — write them in the order they appear in the recording to match the blanks as printed.

Fill each gap with the exact word(s) from the audio description. Apply the technique for single-word and double-blank gaps.

1. *Speaker says: “The project was inspired by my visit to a remote northern country.”*

Gap: Project inspired by a trip to _____

2. *Speaker says: “The main challenges were funding and staffing.”*

Double-blank gap: Main challenges: _____ and _____

3. *Speaker says: “I’d describe the approach as experimental.”*

Gap: Approach described as _____

4. *Speaker says: “The first phase took approximately three months.”*

Gap: First phase duration: _____ months

5. *Speaker says: “She trained under a renowned conductor in a major city.”*

Gap: Trained under a conductor in a major _____ city

6. *Speaker says: “The film score required both live and recorded instruments.”*

Double-blank gap: Score used _____ and _____ instruments

7. *Speaker says: “What sets this technique apart is its simplicity.”*

Gap: Technique distinguished by its _____

8. *Speaker says: “He now collaborates with studios on two different continents.”*

Double-blank gap: Collaborates with studios across two major _____ and _____

9. *Speaker says: “The composition process begins with a visual storyboard.”*

Gap: Composition process begins with a _____

10. *Speaker says: “The most difficult aspect was recreating an authentic acoustic environment.”*

Gap: Most difficult aspect: recreating an authentic _____ environment



Section E — Part 4: Note-Taking (Section B — Single Playback)

Section B is played ONCE ONLY. There is no second chance. Preparation before the audio is essential.

Overview: Q23 sub-questions (i)–(viii) | 8 marks (1 each) | Structured note-taking form with pre-printed headings.

'You do not need to write in full sentences.' Bullet phrases are expected and sufficient.

Sample audio type: An informational student presentation about a planned city.

Headings: (i) Year established · (ii) Location · (iii) Climate · (iv) Reason established · (v) Layout · (vi) Visitors' impressions · (vii) Advantage · (viii) Disadvantage.

Sample answer for (i): **1950s** Sample answer for (vii): **well-planned road network**

Question Type 1: Factual Note-Taking Under Headings

Technique: Write continuously as the speaker talks. Use bullet phrases and abbreviations. Listen for topic pivots (pauses, phrases like *'moving on to'*, *'another aspect is'*) to know when to move to the next heading. The form headings are paraphrased — do not expect to hear the exact heading words.

Step 1. Pre-scan: Scan ALL (i)–(viii) headings in a single sweep before audio begins.

Step 2. Prepare abbreviations: gov, pop, env, adv, disadv, approx, c. (century), yr, b/c (because), → (leading to).

Step 3. Write while listening: Do not stop to think. Skip a gap if you miss it — never leave a blank.

Step 4. Listen for pivots: A pause or *'moving on to'* signals the next heading. Track which heading you are on.

Step 5. Post-recording: Expand abbreviations. Check notes are under the correct heading. Do not improve wording.

Sub-question heading: (iv) Why the city was established.

Speaker says: *"The city was built to serve as a new, purpose-built capital, largely to shift the country's centre of power away from the coast and towards the interior."*

During

audio — write: shift power inland / away from coast

Post-recording — expand: Purpose-built capital; move power from coast to interior.

Acceptable answers: 'to move capital inland', 'shift power to interior', 'purpose-built; away from coast'

Note: You do not need to reproduce the full sentence. A concise phrase that captures the reason earns the mark.



Sub-question heading: (v) Layout of the city. [Two pieces of information required]

Speaker says: “The city is designed in the shape of an aeroplane or a bird in flight. There are two main axes — a monumental axis running north-south, and a residential axis running east-west.”

During

audio — write: aeroplane shape / 2 axes: N-S + E-W

Post-recording — expand: Shaped like aeroplane; two axes (monumental N-S, residential E-W).

Acceptable answers: ‘aeroplane/bird shape’ AND ‘two axes (monumental and residential)’.

Note: Both pieces of information are required for full credit. Writing only the shape or only the axes earns half — check the sub-question mark allocation.

Listen to the following speaker descriptions and write brief notes under each heading. Use abbreviations where appropriate. You may only read each description ONCE before writing.

- (i) **Location:** “The country is a small island nation located just north of the equator, at the tip of a large peninsula.” Note: _____
- (ii) **Population:** “The population is approximately 6 million people, making it one of the most densely populated countries in the world.” Note: _____
- (iii) **Economy:** “The country’s economy is largely driven by trade, finance, and manufacturing.” Note (3 sectors): _____
- (iv) **Climate:** “The climate is tropical, characterised by high humidity and consistent temperatures of around 30 degrees Celsius year-round.” Note: _____
- (v) **Education system:** “The country’s education system is well known for its rigour and its consistently high rankings in international assessments.” Note: _____
- (vi) **Advantage of living there:** “One major advantage is the low crime rate, which makes it one of the safest places in the world.” Note: _____
- (vii) **Disadvantage:** “However, the high cost of living, particularly housing, is a significant drawback for many residents.” Note: _____
- (viii) **Visitors’ impression:** “Many visitors are struck by the cleanliness and efficiency of the public transport system.” Note: _____



Section F — Exam Tips

#	Tip	Detail	Part
1	Use every second of preparation time	While the scripted introduction plays and during music interludes, read ahead. Students who sit passively during introductions consistently underperform.	All
2	The correct MCQ answer is a paraphrase — an exact echo is a trap	If you hear a specific word and see it verbatim in an option, that option is almost certainly placed out of context. The real answer says the same thing differently.	Part 1
3	The answer comes AFTER the contrast marker	When a speaker says 'but', 'however', or 'actually', the examinable point follows immediately. Do not choose based on what was said before.	All
4	Match the speaker's OWN feeling — not the feelings they describe	Speakers often report others' views first. The speaker's own opinion comes after 'but I feel', 'for me personally', or 'what I really think is'.	Part 2
5	Write the exact heard word — do not improve it	Writing a synonym ('enormous' for 'huge') may cost the mark. The gap answer is what the speaker said, not what you prefer.	Parts 3 & 4
6	Never leave a blank in Section B	Part 4 has only one playback. An empty answer guarantees zero. A best guess based on the heading context may earn the mark. When in doubt, write something.	Part 4



Section G — Common Misconceptions

#	Misconception	The Truth	Consequence
1	I can skip the first listen and rely on the second.	The two-pass system requires the first listen to capture gist and easy answers. Waiting means you have neither a gist nor a reference point — you end up doing everything on one rushed pass.	Multiple answers missed across Section A.
2	I heard that exact word in the audio, so that option must be correct.	Exact-word distractors are deliberately placed in MCQ options. The correct answer is almost always a paraphrase. Hearing a word in both the audio and an option should increase your suspicion of that option.	Frequent selection of distractor options in Part 1.
3	Writing a synonym shows better English and should get the mark.	In Parts 3 and 4, the gap answer must be the word the speaker actually used. A synonym — even a correct one — may be marked wrong because the surrounding text is already a paraphrase and the gap is not.	Marks lost on note-completion despite hearing the correct information.
4	In Part 2, the first thing a speaker says is their answer.	Speakers regularly describe others' views before giving their own. The answer is always the speaker's OWN feeling, which typically comes after 'but I feel' or 'for me'.	Matching the wrong sentiment.
5	Listening comprehension cannot be prepared for.	Listening in an exam is a learned skill. Pre-reading questions, predicting word classes, tracking discourse markers, and practising with varied accents all make a measurable difference.	Avoidable marks lost on technique.
6	Section B plays again if I miss something.	Part 4 is played ONCE only. An empty answer guarantees zero. An approximate or partially correct answer may still earn the mark.	Empty answer spaces throughout Part 4.
7	The headings on the Section B form tell me exactly what the speaker will say.	The headings are paraphrased. The speaker introduces each topic using different words. Listen for topic shifts — pauses, 'moving on to', 'another feature of'.	Answers written under the wrong heading.
8	I can use a letter twice in Part 2 if two speakers feel the same way.	'DO NOT USE ANY LETTER MORE THAN ONCE' is absolute. If two speakers seem to share the same feeling, one match is wrong or the two options are more distinct than they appear.	Automatic loss of at least one mark.
9	Missing a qualifier like 'mainly' or 'only' doesn't matter if the general idea is right.	Qualifiers like 'only', 'mainly', 'unlikely', and 'at first' are part of the meaning. A factually correct answer that omits a key qualifier is a wrong answer.	Choosing options that are almost correct in MCQ.
10	The Part 3 graphic organiser goes from top to bottom in one column.	The organiser may branch sideways or have parallel columns. Questions 13–22 follow the audio's order, but the layout does not always match a single linear column. Pre-read the ENTIRE organiser.	Losing track of which gap corresponds to which audio segment.



Final Reminder

Parts 1 & 2 — INTERPRETATION: The answer is rarely the speaker's exact words. Listen for meaning and emotion. **Parts 3 & 4 — TRANSCRIPTION:** Write what the speaker actually said. Never substitute a synonym.

